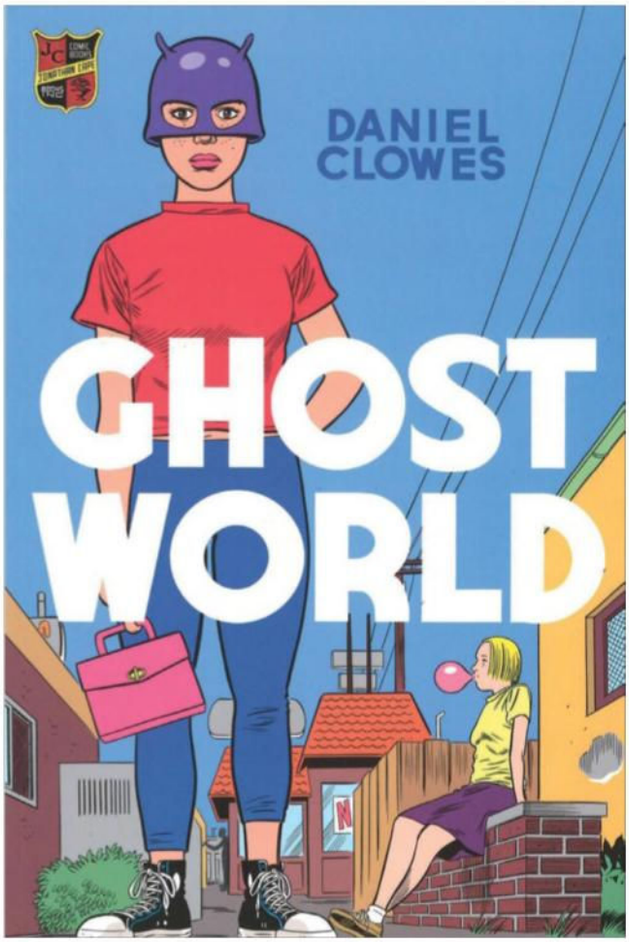


GHOST WORLD

Details **Originally published** 1993-1997 in Eightball **Publisher** Fantagraphics Books **Writer** Daniel Clowes **Artist** Daniel Clowes **Collected in** Ghost World **Available digitally** N/A

There's a reason why *Ghost World* remains the best-known work of writer-artist Daniel Clowes: in short, it's a masterpiece. Originally serialised in Clowes' *Eightball* comic, it's the story of 18-year-old Enid Coleslaw, a disaffected and acid-tongued girl who's keenly aware of the failings of the town where she has the misfortune to live. The unnamed suburb is a wasteland of disappointment to Enid and her best friend Rebecca, who starts as Enid's equal before realising that she's not quite as committed to life as an outsider as her best friend is.

The two move through their neighbourhood and observe the weird, sad lives of their neighbours (sometimes stalking them, sometimes infatuated with them, sometimes just plain curious about them), and it's a beautiful portrait of life as a teenager when the only next step is adulthood. Clowes' distinctive visual style has made Enid an icon, but also captures the strange sense of twilight melancholy that comes from the writing. The world is disappointing and people are weird, but passive observation will only get you so far.

"IT'S A BEAUTIFUL PORTRAIT OF LIFE AS A TEENAGER WHEN THE ONLY NEXT STEP IS ADULTHOOD"

THE PUNISHER MAX: IN THE BEGINNING

Details **Originally published** The Punisher MAX: #1-6 (2004) **Publisher** Marvel **Writer** Garth Ennis **Artist** Lewis Larosa **Collected in** The Punisher Vol 1: In The Beginning **Available digitally** Comixology, Marvel Unlimited

The Punisher always struggled to fit into the traditional Marvel Universe. And so he should have; he's a gun-toting maniac in a city full of superpowered heroes and villains. That's why the mature MAX line led by writer Garth Ennis was so damned successful.

A much older Frank Castle finds himself in a realistic world without superheroes lurking in the skies to clean up his mess, a world where the villains are drug dealers, corrupt politicians and sex traffickers. *The Punisher MAX* is a deliciously violent and unflinching introspective look at a character that's emotionally crippled by his one-man war on crime. The spandex suit and ridiculous sidekicks are replaced by an insatiable blood lust against the crime that runs rampant through New York City.



The Punisher MAX is a blood-soaked thriller that reveals Frank's journey didn't start with three gunshots in a park, but a lifelong desire to punish the wretched.

